

Plan

U-CAN website strategy

12-month plan

June 2026

Phase 1 - Strengthen the foundations (July 2026 - Sept 2026)

1. Rework the homepage:

A. Replace the hero carousel with a single statement

The current three-slide carousel leads with urbanisation statistics before introducing U-CAN. Most visitors will not read all three slides. Replace this with a single headline and one sentence that immediately explains what U-CAN is. Copy to be developed internally; implementation by Shashi.

B. Add the "What we have built together" section

Replace generic descriptions of U-CAN's work with a dedicated impact section that combines headline metrics with key achievements from across the network. Include four to six headline statistics (e.g. practitioners connected, government officials engaged, cities represented, governance innovations supported) alongside short descriptions of major milestones or initiatives. Where appropriate, include participant quotes or tangible outcomes to demonstrate impact.

C. Improve the homepage narrative

Review the order of homepage sections so they tell a clearer story:

- What is U-CAN?
- What have we built together?
- What are we currently working on?
- Who is involved?
- How can visitors engage?

This will help visitors understand the network before introducing its members and initiatives.

2. Refresh the 'About U-CAN' Page

The About page contains comprehensive information about U-CAN but could be made easier to navigate and digest.

Potential improvements include:

- Breaking long sections of text into shorter, more readable blocks.
- Introducing stronger headings and visual hierarchy between sections.
- Presenting the Core Principles in a more visual format.
- Adding short introductory text to the Leadership and Stewardship sections explaining their role within the network.
- Reviewing the presentation of the timeline to improve readability while retaining existing content.

3. Strengthen the Urban Reforms Collective Page

Develop the URC page into the primary landing page for the initiative. Actions include:

- Add a summary of the inaugural convening and its key outcomes.
- Move the Expression of Interest form higher on the page.
- Introduce participating organisations.
- Add reform clusters and thematic priorities.
- Publish publicly available outputs and resources from the convening.
- Clearly communicate next steps and opportunities for participation as the initiative develops.

4. Strengthen the Request for Collaboration Page

Demonstrate how the mechanism works by showcasing tangible examples. Actions include:

- Add a short case study highlighting the outcome of a completed Request for Collaboration.
- Introduce the organisations involved and the resulting product or output.
- Clarify the collaboration process and what organisations can expect after submitting a request - i.e. the toolkit.

Phase 2 - Deepen each initiative's presence (Oct 2026 - Feb 2027)

1. URC - ongoing updates

The URC will be the primary focus of this phase as the reform agenda develops. The page should be updated continuously to reflect new participating organisations, emerging reform priorities, and outcomes from collective engagements.

2. World Cities Day - October 30/31

Build a web presence around U-CAN's World Cities Day activity ahead of the event. This is an opportunity to position the URC's work within a global moment and reach a wider audience. Page or section to be live well before the date.

3. City Mixers

Keep the archive updated after each mixer so the page never looks inactive.

Phase 3 - Measure and grow (March 2027 - June 2027)

1. Annual Forum 2027

A stronger pre-event page with agenda, speakers, and a clear reason to attend helps drive registrations and signals that U-CAN is building momentum year on year.

2. Review website performance

Assess website analytics after one year to understand:

- which pages attract the most visitors
- where users are entering and leaving the website
- which content drives newsletter subscriptions
- which pages generate Expressions of Interest or collaboration enquiries

Use these insights to prioritise future improvements.

3. Refresh core website content

Undertake an annual review of key pages to:

- update impact figures
- refresh initiative pages
- archive outdated content
- replace broken links
- ensure information remains current

Home page

Homepage

Previous:

U-CAN brings together people, communities, policymakers, and state agencies from Tier II and Tier III Indian cities to collaboratively solve urban challenges—creating a safer, more inclusive, and more livable urban experience.

New:

Turning individual effort into collective action across India's cities and towns

U-CAN convenes urban practitioners, governments, researchers and philanthropies to champion liveable cities for their residents and communicate what works from one city to the next.

[Explore our work →]



(Key attendees at U-CAN's first Annual

Forum]

—

WHY U-CAN?

India's urban challenges are too complex for any one organisation to solve alone, so we create the conditions to enable collaboration between organisations.

Most of what shapes urban policy in India comes from a handful of metropolitan cities. But the real story, and much of the country's urban growth, is playing out in nearly 10,000 smaller towns and cities, often with little data and even less coordination between the people working to improve them.

U-CAN exists to be the connective tissue that's missing: a trusted space for practitioners, government, researchers and philanthropies to connect, learn from each other, and act together.

The spark for U-CAN emerged from two intertwined realisations. First, we may be running out of time for slow, linear change; our cities need bold, accelerated action built on collective momentum. Second, when the right people and ideas meet in a shared conversation, they can catalyse transformative change at scale. U-CAN was born from that belief: a space for collaboration beyond boundaries.

Shilpa Kumar, Founding Member, U-CAN and Managing Director & Head of India, British International Investment

WHAT WE DO

Our 3Cs of Collective Action

01 · Convene — Create spaces to connect

Through City Mixers, webinars and structured Requests for Collaboration, we create safe spaces for members to share what's worked, what hasn't, and where they might work together.

02 · Champion — Align action, drive reform

We help members align strategies, pool resources and coordinate action around shared goals, working through the Urban Reforms Collective's engagement with government and a shared narrative on the role of Tier II and III cities in India's growth.

03 · Communicate — Build the case for cities

The Annual Forum and our peer learning communities help make the case for greater investment in India's urban sector, giving donors a clear, collective view of the challenges and opportunities ahead.

IMPACT

What we've built together

Here's what collective action has already produced, in numbers and in the stories behind them.

AT A GLANCE

- **8** — Member organisations
- **500+** — Practitioners connected
- **200+** — Government officials engaged
- **25+** — Cities represented

01 — Bringing policy and lived experience to the same table

The Annual Forum brought 100+ participants across 20+ organisations together, including government officials at the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs.

02 — Advancing women's voices in urban practice

The U-CAN Women's Fellowship's inaugural, all-women cohort of 6 professionals and 2 entrepreneurs worked through embedded practice and mentorship, on projects spanning Gurugram, Bengaluru, Jaipur and Chennai.

03 — Scaling a governance platform across borders

The Request for Collaboration initiative turned cross-organisation work into a governance platform now running in 3 Indian cities and Nairobi, Kenya.

04 — Reaching 15,000+ people on urban issues

Through 4 podcast episodes, 10+ webinars, and 30+ newsletters, U-CAN has built an audience for substantive conversation about India's urban challenges.

[See our full impact →]

OUR MEMBERS

Our Members
Friends of U-CAN

STAY CONNECTED

Keep up to date with U-CAN's initiatives, events and opportunities to collaborate.

[Subscribe]

SEO-Adapted Copy

Meta

Title tag:

Urban Collective Action Network for India's cities | U-CAN

Meta description:

U-CAN unites urban practitioners, government and philanthropies to build liveable Indian cities. See how we are driving change.

Hero

H1:

Turning individual effort into collective action across India's cities and towns

Opening hook:

U-CAN is a national network connecting urban practitioners, government officials, researchers and philanthropies working to build more liveable cities across India. Since launching, the network has brought together 500+ practitioners, 200+ government officials and 25+ cities to share what works and act on it together. Here's how U-CAN turns individual effort into collective action, and what it's helped build so far.

CTA: **Explore our work** →

Hero image alt text:

alt="Practitioners, researchers, media and government officials at U-CAN's first Annual Forum"

Why U-CAN?

H2:

India's urban challenges are too complex for any one organisation to solve alone, so we create the conditions to enable collaboration between organisations.

Body:

Most urban policy in India is shaped by a handful of metropolitan cities, but most of the country's urban growth is happening in nearly 10,000 smaller towns and cities, often with little data and even less coordination. U-CAN exists to be the connective tissue and safe space for practitioners, government, researchers and philanthropies to connect, learn from each other, and act together.

The spark for U-CAN emerged from two intertwined realisations. First, we may be running out of time for slow, linear change; our cities need bold, accelerated action built on collective momentum. Second, when the right people and ideas meet in a shared conversation, they can catalyse transformative change at scale. U-CAN was born from that belief: a space for collaboration beyond boundaries.

Shilpa Kumar, Founding Member, U-CAN and Managing Director & Head of India, British International Investment

Our 3Cs of Collective Action

H3 section title:

Our 3Cs of Collective Action - keep as-is

Impact

H2 (kept):

What we've built together - keep as-in

CTA: **See our full impact** → (unchanged)

Our Members

Alt text ="[Member organisation name] logo"

Stay Connected

H2 (keep as-is):

Keep up to date with U-CAN's initiatives, events and opportunities to collaborate.

CTA: **Subscribe** (unchanged)

Summary of changes made

Element	Before	After
Title tag	U-CAN: Urban Collective Action Network (no keyword front-loading, no differentiator)	U-CAN – Urban Collective Action Network for India's cities
Meta description	Missing entirely	Added
Opening hook	Led with what U-CAN does	Leads with what U-CAN <i>is</i>

Hero image alt	None	Added, subject + context
Body copy	Good, fact-dense	Minor inverted-pyramid tightening only
Headings	Already solid	Left mostly untouched

As discussed, please share some FAQs related to U-CAN.

About us

ABOUT US ▾

- Vision
 - Mission
 - Governing Principles
 - Timeline
 - Our People
 - Impact
-

About Us — SEO-Adapted Copy

Meta

Title tag: About U-CAN | Urban Collective Action Network

Meta description: Learn about U-CAN's vision, mission and guiding principles for building more livable, inclusive Indian cities, and how the network has grown since 2022.

H1: About U-CAN

Opening hook:

U-CAN is a network of organisations working together to strengthen urban problem-solving in India's Tier II and Tier III cities. Formed in 2022 by a founding circle of twelve city-focused organisations, U-CAN today convenes practitioners, government officials, researchers and philanthropies around one shared goal: safer, more inclusive, better-governed cities for their residents.

VISION (remains the same)

ADD - [Download our Brochure →]

MISSION (remains the same)

GOVERNING PRINCIPLES (remains the same)

TIMELINE (remains the same, only 1 addition):

June 2026 — Launch of the Urban Reforms Collective in Mumbai.

12 organisations signed the Mumbai Declaration, marking the formal launch of the Urban Reforms Collective.

[Meet our people →]

[See our full impact →]

STAY CONNECTED

Keep up to date with U-CAN's initiatives, events and opportunities to collaborate.
[Subscribe]

Our People — SEO-Adapted Copy

Meta title: Our People | U-CAN, Urban Collective Action Network

Meta description: Meet the founders, steering committee and team driving U-CAN's work to strengthen urban problem-solving in India's cities.

H1: Our People

Opening hook: U-CAN is run by a small backbone team and guided by a wider circle of founders and member representatives who steer the network's strategy and hold it accountable to its mission.

1. Founding Circle
2. Steering Committee
3. Stewardship Team
4. Our team

Back to About Us →

Explore our impact →

Impact — SEO-Adapted Copy

Meta title: Our Impact | U-CAN, Urban Collective Action Network

Meta description: See U-CAN's impact in numbers and stories, from peer learning networks and the Request for Collaboration to the Fellowship, City Mixers and Roots and Horizons.

H1: What We've Built Together

Opening hook: Since 2022, U-CAN has turned individual effort into collective action across dozens of Indian cities. Here's what that collaboration has produced so far

01

Increased learning opportunities and knowledge exchange across mid-level administration through Communities of Learning, spanning 200 officials across 25+ cities in 3 states.

02

Developed a governance innovation platform through structured cross-organisational collaboration through the Request for Collaboration (RFC) initiative. The platform is now being implemented in 3 Indian cities and Nairobi, Kenya.

03

Activated place-based ecosystems through 10+ City Mixers, connecting 500+ practitioners, researchers, funders, communicators, and community leaders across sectors to increase understanding of urban systems.

"I truly enjoyed the U-CAN mixer at the WRI Delhi office, the format felt refreshing, focusing less on project presentations and more on personal journeys and what inspires our work."

— Nidhi Batra, Founder, Sehreeti Development Practices

04

Mainstreaming urban discourse using various media channels

4 podcast episodes, 10+ webinars and 30+ newsletters reaching an audience of 15,000+.

05

Advanced voices of women in the urban sector

with the U-CAN Women's Fellowship, supporting 6 professionals and 2 entrepreneurs through embedded practice and mentorship. Projects spanned a rainwater harvesting calculator piloted in Gurugram, ward-level climate action plans in Bengaluru, and redesigning public spaces in Jaipur and Chennai.

"The U-CAN Fellowship became a transformative space to deepen this pursuit, through hands-on work with host organisations, writing blogs, and co-developing solutions that strengthened my understanding of data-driven and participatory approaches to urban resilience." — Shubhi Kesarwani

06

Organised participatory and non-hierarchical space

bringing together practitioners, community leaders, and government on a common platform, The U-CAN Annual Forum. Strengthened trust and deepened cross-sector relationships amongst 100+ participants across 20+ organisations.

"The Annual Forum was a valuable space for bringing together diverse voices from across the urban ecosystem. It helped us reflect on how national policy priorities connect with the lived realities of cities." — Gurjit Singh Dhillon, Director, Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs

07

Initiated a shift from a programmatic approach to a strategic approach for state-level engagement. Convened teams across 5 organisations in a series of discussions for Uttar Pradesh to align infrastructure-focused planning with community-grounded action.

08

Developed a knowledge commons, 'Roots and Horizons'

To increase visibility of organisational work, journeys, practices and futures of 9 organisations to peers and donors.

In their words

"It is extremely useful to hear from the other members and their state teams who have been working in Uttar Pradesh for years. As a new entrant in the state, we learnt how the state machinery functions, how officials perceive us and what we need to do for them to value our work, thereby shortening our learning curve."

- Pratima Joshi, Founder and Executive Director, Shelter Associates

"Emerging cities today tell us that growth is not something you can design on paper, it's something you build through trust, collaboration, and constant learning. Real change happens when intent, leadership, and citizen energy start to move in the same direction."

- Mayura Gadkari, Principal, Artha Centre for Emerging Cities, Artha Global

"Each organisation in U-CAN has its own story, shaped by years of working in different cities, with different communities and challenges. Yet, through this collective, those stories connect, revealing patterns, shared struggles, and possibilities that none of us could see alone."

- Meghna Indurkar, Head of Strategic Communication, Praja Foundation

[Explore our initiatives →]

U-CAN Fellowship

Title tag: The U-CAN Fellowship

Meta description: The U-CAN Fellowship is a year-long program placing women leaders inside urban institutions across India. See what the 2024-25 cohort built.

H1: Empowering Women Change-Makers to Transform Urban Communities

Lede: The U-CAN Fellowship was a program designed to empower passionate leaders dedicated to driving sustainable urban development and fostering community engagement across India. Its inaugural cohort ran in 2024-25.

About the Fellowship

Over a 12-month period, U-CAN Fellows embarked on an immersive learning journey, collaborating with civic leaders, urban planners, and social innovators to tackle some of the most pressing challenges in urban development. The fellowship integrated hands-on fieldwork, professional mentorship, and skill-building workshops, empowering a new generation of change-makers to drive impactful solutions in urban spaces.

Program Highlights

The U-CAN Fellowship was not just an academic experience, it was a chance to work directly on the problems shaping India's cities. Fellows gained:

- **On-the-Ground Experience** — Live urban projects alongside local communities, municipal bodies, and policy experts, solving real-world urban challenges.
- **Workshops and Training** — Workshops, training sessions, and expert-led discussions to develop practical skills and knowledge critical to urban development.
- **Networking Opportunities** — Lasting relationships within a vibrant community of organizations and urban experts, fostering collaboration and ongoing learning in the urban sector.
- **Project Focus** — Each fellow tackled a key urban issue through a project, with mentorship and support from their assigned organization.
- **Expert Mentorship** — Peer-to-peer mentorship within the cohort, plus guidance from U-CAN member organizations, the U-CAN CEO, and the extensive alumni network, with access to potential funding, grants, or investment networks through the U-CAN platform.
- **Funding** — A one-year commitment in the form of a competitive stipend, supporting fellows' work and learning throughout the fellowship.

Urban Challenges Fellows Addressed

Fellows worked on housing affordability, transportation, environmental sustainability, and inclusion, each embedded for a year with a single host organisation. The specific projects, city by city, are documented in the report below.

Shaping Urban Futures: Stories from the U-CAN Fellowship

India's cities are full of possibility, but women are largely missing from the leadership spaces shaping them, despite being among those most affected by decisions on mobility, safety, public space, and climate.

The U-CAN Fellowship was created to bridge this gap and ask a crucial question: what becomes possible when women lead urban transformation?

Over one year, eight women Fellows embedded themselves within leading urban institutions across India, working alongside governments, community networks, researchers, and non-profits to solve real problems on the ground. From clean air zones and climate action planning to participatory governance and public-space redesign, their work demonstrates the power of placing diverse leadership at the centre of city-making.

How the Fellowship Is Designed

The programme was intentionally built as a platform that:

- Promotes women's leadership in the urban development ecosystem, ensuring diverse perspectives and more equitable representation in decision-making spaces.
- Attracts talented mid-career professionals and social entrepreneurs to nurture cross-sector learning and engage meaningfully in shaping India's urban development landscape.
- Builds structured leadership pathways, combining on-ground problem-solving with mentorship, peer learning, and exposure to global best practices.

What It Aims to Cultivate

Fellows are supported through three core enablers that shape their leadership journey:

- **Knowledge** — Immersive learning experiences that blend mentorship, masterclasses, field insights, and peer exchange, helping Fellows develop both strategic and practical skills for urban problem-solving.
- **Network** — Access to a connected ecosystem of government institutions, host organisations, practitioners, and technical experts, opening doors to collaboration and long-term pathways in the urban sector.
- **Funding** — A dedicated one-year grant that provides the stability and flexibility to experiment, co-create solutions with stakeholders, and demonstrate credible impact on the ground.

Together, these pillars create the conditions for Fellows to build confidence, capability, and influence, enabling them to shape more equitable, resilient cities across India.

Inside this publication, you will find:

- The journeys and lived experiences of the inaugural cohort
- The solutions they built with institutions and communities
- And the Fellowship model that supported them

[[Read the Full Report →](#)]

Who Were the 2024-25 Fellows?

1. Aanchal Aggarwal — Janaagraha
2. Aashima Arora — WRI India & U-CAN
3. Anweshha Bhattacharya — Safetipin
4. Manisha Bisht — Shelter Associates
5. Ramya M A — Artha Global
6. Sharathppriyaa Venkatesan — Reap Benefit
7. Shubhi Kesarwani — GURUJAL
8. Shreya Krishnan — SKDO

[[Meet Our Fellows →](#)]

Blogs by fellows

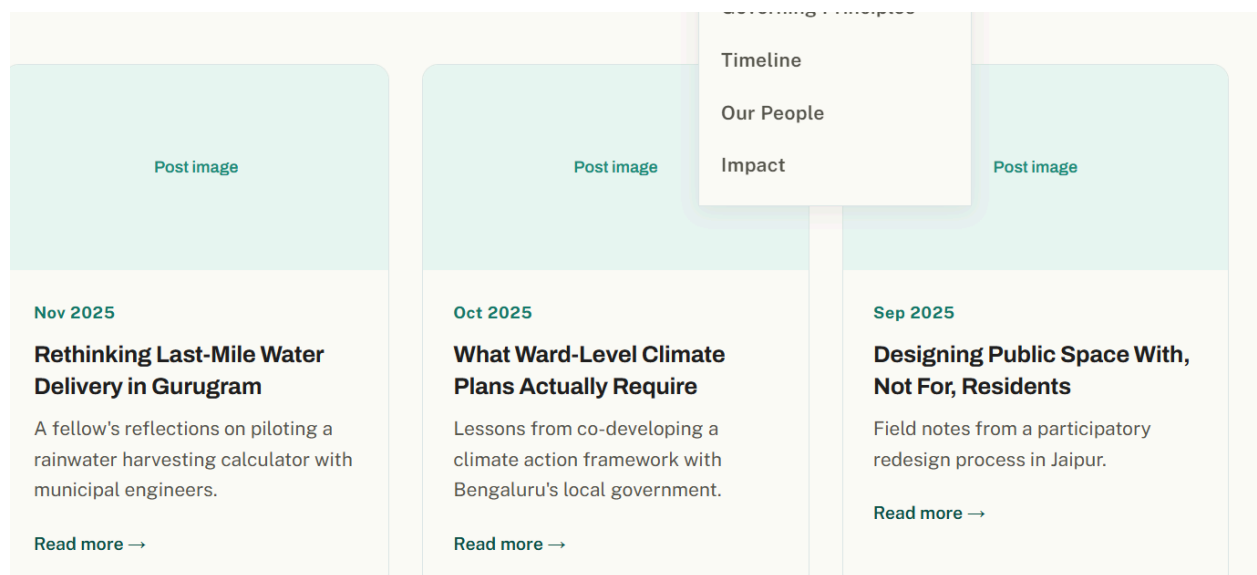
Meta title: Blogs by Our Fellows | U-CAN, Urban Collective Action Network

Meta description: Read stories and reflections from U-CAN Fellows working on urban governance, climate action and public space design across Indian cities.

H1: Blogs by Our Fellows

Intro line:

Reflections and field notes from the U-CAN Fellowship, written by fellows working directly with host institutions across India's cities.



Meet our Fellows

Meet the 2024-25 Fellows — Full Page Content

Title tag: Meet the 2024-25 Fellows | U-CAN Fellowship

Meta description: Meet the eight women leaders of U-CAN's inaugural Fellowship cohort, hosted across India's leading urban institutions in 2024-25.

H1: Meet the 2024-25 Fellows

Lede: Eight women leaders, embedded for a year within urban institutions across India, working on housing, transportation, sustainability, and inclusion.

Fellow grid (name, host org, photo alt text — bios live on individual profile pages, not here):

1. **Aanchal Aggarwal** — Janaagraha
alt="Aanchal Aggarwal, U-CAN Fellow at Janaagraha, portrait photo"
2. **Aashima Arora** — WRI India & U-CAN
alt="Aashima Arora, U-CAN Fellow at WRI India, portrait photo"
3. **Anweshha Bhattacharya** — Safetipin
alt="Anweshha Bhattacharya, U-CAN Fellow at Safetipin, portrait photo"
4. **Manisha Bisht** — Shelter Associates
alt="Manisha Bisht, U-CAN Fellow at Shelter Associates, portrait photo"
5. **Ramya M A** — Artha Global
alt="Ramya M A, U-CAN Fellow at Artha Global, portrait photo"
6. **Sharathppriyaa Venkatesan** — Reap Benefit
alt="Sharathppriyaa Venkatesan, U-CAN Fellow at Reap Benefit, portrait photo"
7. **Shubhi Kesarwani** — GuruJal
alt="Shubhi Kesarwani, U-CAN Fellow at GuruJal, portrait photo"
8. **Shreya Krishnan** — SKDO
alt="Shreya Krishnan, U-CAN Fellow at SKDO, portrait photo"

Each card links to that fellow's individual profile page ("View Details").

Meet the 2024-25 Fellows — SEO Metadata for Individual Profile Pages

(bios are unchanged, this is the title tag and meta description to attach to each existing profile page)



MEET THE FELLOW

AANCHAL AGGARWAL

Aanchal Aggarwal, a former J&K Lieutenant Governor Sustainable Development Fellow, collaborated with the J&K Government on Urban Development projects with a special focus on Public Realm Design, Urban Greening, and Mobility. With a Master's in Architecture and over seven years of experience in Architecture and Urban Development, Aanchal is dedicated to creating inclusive, people-centric urban spaces.

As a recipient of the UCAN Fellowship, Aanchal will work with the Civic Leadership and Participation team at Janaagraha to research, identify, and scale pathways for citizen participation in urban planning across India. Her passion lies in making the built environment accessible and inclusive, always placing people at the heart of her designs.

In her spare time, Aanchal enjoys hiking, reading, and documenting city life through photography. She also conducts Heritage Walks in her hometown and actively volunteers with local NGOs.


HOST ORGANIZATION
Janaagraha


JOINING LOCATION
Bangalore


EDUCATION
M. Arch



Aanchal Aggarwal (Janaagraha)

Title tag: Aanchal Aggarwal — U-CAN Fellow, Janaagraha | U-CAN

Meta description: Aanchal Aggarwal, U-CAN Fellow at Janaagraha, researched pathways for citizen participation in urban planning with the Civic Leadership and Participation team.

Aashima Arora (WRI India)

Title tag: Aashima Arora — U-CAN Fellow, WRI India | U-CAN

Meta description: Aashima Arora, U-CAN Fellow at WRI India, focused on youth-led urban development initiatives driving inclusive, community-led design in Jaipur.

Anwesha Bhattacharya (Safetipin)

Title tag: Anwesha Bhattacharya — U-CAN Fellow, Safetipin | U-CAN

Meta description: Anwesha Bhattacharya, U-CAN Fellow at Safetipin, is an urban planner specializing in pilgrimage city planning and gender safety in public spaces.

Manisha Bisht (Shelter Associates)

Title tag: Manisha Bisht — U-CAN Fellow, Shelter Associates | U-CAN

Meta description: Manisha Bisht, U-CAN Fellow at Shelter Associates, researches and designs solutions for food security, waste management, and community engagement.

Ramya M A (Artha Global)

Title tag: Ramya M A — U-CAN Fellow, Artha Global | U-CAN

Meta description: Ramya M A, U-CAN Fellow at Artha Global, is developing a national capacity-building program for urban leaders, including the CAZ project.

Sharathpriyaa Venkatesan (Reap Benefit)

Title tag: Sharathpriyaa Venkatesan — U-CAN Fellow, Reap Benefit | U-CAN

Meta description: Sharathpriyaa Venkatesan, U-CAN Fellow at Reap Benefit, focuses on data-driven governance to support sustainable urban development practices.

Shubhi Kesarwani (GuruJal)

Title tag: Shubhi Kesarwani — U-CAN Fellow, GuruJal | U-CAN

Meta description: Shubhi Kesarwani, U-CAN Fellow, social entrepreneur and founder of GuruJal, leads work on water security and natural resource conservation across India.

Shreya Krishnan (SKDO)

Title tag: Shreya Krishnan — U-CAN Fellow, SKDO | U-CAN

Meta description: Shreya Krishnan, U-CAN Fellow, social entrepreneur and Principal Architect at SKDO, brings 12+ years of award-winning urban design and policy experience.

L&D Calendar

Title tag: Fellowship L&D Calendar | U-CAN

Meta description: Browse the U-CAN Fellowship's full Learning & Development calendar, past sessions on urban governance, storytelling, climate resilience, and housing.

H1: L&D Calendar

Intro: The L&D Calendar was where fellows accessed and reviewed training sessions throughout the program, a clear schedule of masterclasses, workshops, and expert sessions covering everything from data storytelling to urban governance to housing policy. Browse the calendar below to see the full range of learning fellows engaged with over the year.

{Then full list in descending order}

SEO Metadata for All 12 Sessions *(each pulls one specific, verifiable fact from that session's actual content, not a generic template; same approach as the Fellows page)*

1. Roof Over Our Heads (ROOH): Reframing Urban Poor Habitats

Title tag: Roof Over Our Heads (ROOH): Reframing Urban Poor Habitats — U-CAN Fellowship L&D | U-CAN

Meta description: A U-CAN Fellowship L&D session on the Roof Over Our Heads (ROOH) initiative, featuring community-led housing models from Nairobi, Mumbai, and Surat.

2. Leveraging Digital Public Infrastructure for Urban Transformation

Title tag: Leveraging Digital Public Infrastructure for Urban Transformation — U-CAN Fellowship L&D | U-CAN

Meta description: A U-CAN Fellowship L&D session on Digital Public Infrastructure, led by eGov Foundation's Sowmya V, using India's DIGIT platform as a case study.

3. Exploring Informality: Informal Settlements, Development and Climate Change

Title tag: Exploring Informality: Informal Settlements, Development and Climate Change — U-CAN Fellowship L&D | U-CAN

Meta description: A U-CAN Fellowship L&D session led by SPARC founder Sheela Patel on informal settlements, development, and the disproportionate impact of climate change.

4. Living with Climate Stressors: Urban Resilience and Climate Adaptation

Title tag: Living with Climate Stressors: Urban Resilience and Climate Adaptation — U-CAN Fellowship L&D | U-CAN

Meta description: A U-CAN Fellowship L&D session on urban heat resilience, led by UN-Habitat's Global Chief Heat Officer Dr. Eleni Myrivili.

5. Storytelling Masterclass 4: Using Oral Stories at Work

Title tag: Storytelling Masterclass 4: Using Oral Stories at Work — U-CAN Fellowship L&D | U-CAN

Meta description: The fourth U-CAN Fellowship storytelling masterclass, led by Vansh Chopra of Storywallahs, on using oral storytelling techniques at work.

6. Urban Planning in India: Experiences and Lessons for the Future

Title tag: Urban Planning in India: Experiences and Lessons for the Future — U-CAN Fellowship L&D | U-CAN

Meta description: A U-CAN Fellowship L&D session with CPR India's Champaka Rajagopal on urban planning law and lessons from India's major master plans.

7. Storytelling Masterclass 3: Storyboarding and Visual Communication for Impact

Title tag: Storytelling Masterclass 3: Storyboarding and Visual Communication — U-CAN Fellowship L&D | U-CAN

Meta description: The third U-CAN Fellowship storytelling masterclass, covering deck storyboarding and visual simplification with Storywallahs' Chirantan Bhabhra.

8. Storytelling Masterclass 2: Using Data to Create Impactful Narratives

Title tag: Storytelling Masterclass 2: Using Data to Create Impactful Narratives — U-CAN Fellowship L&D | U-CAN

Meta description: The second U-CAN Fellowship storytelling masterclass, on turning raw data into compelling narratives, led by Storywallahs' Chirantan Bhabhra.

9. Urban Governance 2: Right to Information (RTI) & Citizens

Title tag: Urban Governance 2: Right to Information (RTI) & Citizens — U-CAN Fellowship L&D | U-CAN

Meta description: A U-CAN Fellowship L&D session with Praja Foundation's Eknath Pawar on using the RTI Act for participatory democracy and civic accountability.

10. Urban Governance 1: Structure & Status

Title tag: Urban Governance 1: Structure & Status — U-CAN Fellowship L&D | U-CAN

Meta description: A U-CAN Fellowship L&D session with Praja Foundation's Aviral Dubey on India's three-tiered urban governance structure and fiscal empowerment.

11. Thinking Better, Alone Together

Title tag: Thinking Better, Alone Together — U-CAN Fellowship L&D | U-CAN

Meta description: A U-CAN Fellowship L&D session on Nancy Kline's Thinking Environment, led by facilitator Manali Shah.

12. Storytelling Masterclass 1: Introduction to Storytelling at Work

Title tag: Storytelling Masterclass 1: Introduction to Storytelling at Work — U-CAN Fellowship L&D | U-CAN

Meta description: The first U-CAN Fellowship storytelling masterclass, introducing frameworks like BLUF to communicate work with clarity and impact.

Listing page (the calendar itself):

Title tag: Fellowship L&D Calendar | U-CAN

Meta description: Browse the U-CAN Fellowship's full Learning & Development calendar, past sessions on urban governance, storytelling, climate resilience, and housing.

Events

U-CAN City Mixers

Title tag: U-CAN City Mixers | U-CAN

Meta description: U-CAN City Mixers bring together member organisations and urban practitioners for evenings of dialogue, film, and reflection on India's urban challenges.

H1: U-CAN City Mixers

Photo alt text formula: [Event description] at U-CAN City Mixer, [Host Org], [City], [Date]

List:



Hosted by **WRI India**

April 11, 2025 - Bangalore

The first-ever U-CAN City Mixer brought member organisations together for an evening buzzing with curiosity and energy. Conversations flowed across urban systems, climate resilience, and inclusive planning. One standout moment was Dr. Siji Chacko from Jan Sahas sharing insights on putting migrant workers at the heart of climate resilience efforts. The discussion that followed was timely, grounded, and deeply resonant, setting the tone for what it means to learn together as a community.



Hosted by Artha Global

April 14, 2025 – Mumbai

The mixer unfolded into a rich evening of dialogue and reflection. Dr. Anita Patil-Deshmukh of PUKAR shared her experiences with participatory urban research, sparking thoughtful exchanges with peers from Praja Foundation, Shelter Associates, and other member organisations. Across conversations, the power of thinking out loud with peers who care about the same complex questions was palpable.



Hosted by Janaagraha

July 17, 2025 - Bangalore

Back in Bangalore, Janaagraha welcomed the U-CAN community with warmth and insight. Vishwanath S shared compelling stories from the water ecosystem, drawing lessons from cities across India. Srikanth Viswanatha, CEO, offered a glimpse into Janaagraha's culture, sparking conversations about what it takes to shift city systems. Through speed networking, storytelling, and reflection, one thing became clear: openness and curiosity create real collective power.



Hosted by Praja Foundation

October 10, 2025 - Mumbai

In Mumbai, our October mixer with Praja Foundation turned into an evening of honest reflection on what it takes to strengthen city systems from within. Former councillor Ravi Raja shared insights from his years in public service, sparking dialogue on how governance, transparency, and trust evolve over time. The conversations reminded us that lasting reform is built through continuity.



Hosted By WRI India

December 12, 2025 - New Delhi

In December, our City Mixer opened beyond U-CAN membership, bringing together urban practitioners, researchers, and students for an evening of curiosity and dialogue. We were delighted to have Nidhi Batra, Founder of Sehreeti Developmental Practices Foundation, share her work in participatory research and community engagement in Delhi's historic neighbourhoods, Mehrauli and Chandni Chowk, using poetry and art to explore memory, place, and urban practice. She also highlighted Sehreeti's biodiversity initiatives with young people in Haryana and Gurugram, including using community radio to amplify citizens' voices.



Hosted by Praja Foundation

December 19, 2025 – Mumbai

To wrap up 2025, Praja Foundation hosted a U-CAN City Mixer in Mumbai, bringing people together for an evening of dialogue and reflection. Prof. Amita Bhide from TISS shared insights from her long-standing work with urban poor communities, community organisations, and housing rights movements. Her stories sparked conversations on how urban change is shaped through sustained dialogue, grounded research, and collective action.



Hosted by Reap Benefit

January 30, 2026 - Bangalore

We began 2026 with our first City Mixer of the year, hosted by Reap Benefit, and experimented with a new format: “Adda.” In this open, unstructured space, anyone could speak for five to seven minutes on a topic of their choice. What emerged were candid reflections and questions that rarely surface in formal settings, reminding us that meaningful dialogue often begins by loosening structure. Our Urban Champion, Sailee Rane, Head of Ecosystem Messaging at Rainmatter Foundation, shared her work on building a community of climate narrative builders. From simplifying climate news to creative practices like “100 Days of Blue Skies,” she reflected on how storytelling can make climate change immediate, human, and harder to ignore.



Hosted by Centre for Policy Research

February 20, 2026 – New Delhi

In February, we gathered at the Centre for Policy Research in New Delhi for a City Mixer that asked a simple but unsettling question: where is the demand for collective action in our cities today? Guided by our Urban Champion, Jagan Shah, the conversation examined whether collective action has been reduced to a technocratic tool, and what it means to act meaningfully together in contexts where participation can feel procedural. Drawing on thinkers such as Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, Hannah Arendt, and Richard Sennett, the discussion moved between theory and lived experience, leaving us with a shared recognition that collective action must be continually nurtured, not assumed.



Hosted by eGov Foundation

April 10, 2026 - Bangalore

In April, we hosted our first City Mixer in collaboration with the Charles Correa Foundation and Nagari Short Films, hosted by eGov Foundation. The evening focused on water, not just as a policy problem, but as a shared urban experience that is personal, uneven, and often invisible until it isn't. Screenings of 'Pipe Dream', 'The Many Journeys of Water', and 'Samayada Harivu' (Flow of Time) traced how water moves through cities and through people's lives, bringing together filmmakers, practitioners, and urban thinkers for the conversation.

Reflections from Shruti Parthasarathy (Founder, ReRooted.Films), Vikash Tiwari (director of 'Samayada Harivu'), and Vishwanath S (Director, Biome Environmental Solutions, and Professor, Azim Premji University) drew out questions of access and ownership, the visible and invisible actors shaping who gets water and who doesn't, and the systems that continue working, or failing, long after water leaves the tap. As the conversation turned to Bangalore, it took in the city's lakes and surrounding communities, the challenges of equitable access, and the often overlooked realities of sewage and sanitation that underpin urban life.



Hosted by Artha Global

April 24, 2026 - Mumbai

On April 24th, we brought the City Mixer to Mumbai, in continued collaboration with the Charles Correa Foundation and Nagari Short Films. We opened with a simple question: name a street, a corner, or a spot in the city that feels truly yours, and why. It drew out specific, lived-in answers, and did something more deliberate: it located people in the city before asking them to step outside it.

The three films that followed took the conversation to Dhobi Talao (Mumbai), Guwahati, and Delhi, tracing how cities are shaped through ongoing negotiation over space, ecology, and infrastructure. Two of the three stories were not about Mumbai, yet the room did not treat them as distant. Reflections from Sarah Zia, Sudhanshu Patra, and Anubhav Borgohain helped hold this movement across contexts, drawing connections while also pushing on the limits of those comparisons. What is beginning to emerge across these mixers is not a shared set of answers, but a shared way of reading cities. Each context changes how the others are understood, and that feels like where something useful is starting to take shape.



Hosted by Shelter Associates

May 15, 2026 - Pune

We brought the City Mixer to Pune, in collaboration with the Charles Correa Foundation and Nagari Short Films, hosted by Shelter Associates. Screenings of *A Work in Progress* and *Homes on the Line* set the tone for shared experiences and a conversation with speakers Nipun Prabhakar, Amit Rathee, and Dhanashree Gurav.

The discussions opened up reflections on how cities are shaped and experienced on the ground. From the realities of informal settlements and the often unseen costs of large-scale development, to the quiet ingenuity of communities reusing construction and demolition waste, the conversation surfaced the layered ways in which urban change is lived and negotiated. It also explored possible solutions, existing ones, and different modes of engagement.

It concluded with a shared understanding that accountability must work both ways between institutions and citizens, reaffirming the role of citizens as active participants in shaping neighbourhoods, strengthening local systems, and imagining more equitable urban futures.

Annual Forum 2025

U-CAN Annual Forum 2025

Title tag (44 chars):

U-CAN Annual Forum 2025: Panjim, Goa | U-CAN

Meta description (152 chars):

70+ practitioners, policymakers and community leaders gathered in Panjim, Goa for U-CAN's first Annual Forum. See the sessions, reflections and photos.

H1:

The U-CAN Annual Forum 2025

Opening hook:

The U-CAN Annual Forum is U-CAN's flagship gathering, "Cities. People. Practice. Together." Held for the first time from 21–23 August 2025 in Panjim, Goa, the Forum marked a milestone three years into U-CAN's collective journey, what began as a collaboration of twelve organisations has grown into a space of trust, shared purpose, and experimentation in advancing urban transformation in India's smaller cities.

Over 70 practitioners, elected representatives, policymakers, researchers, and community leaders came together to co-create solutions for India's urban future. Designed to break away from the conventional conference model, the Forum placed collaboration and co-creation at its core. Instead of presentations, sessions created space for participants from diverse roles and backgrounds to reflect, contribute, and connect meaningfully.

The Forum underscored a central truth: India's urban challenges cannot be solved by any single actor. By convening this diverse ecosystem, U-CAN deepened its collective commitment to act for impact.

Section H2s:

- "Quick Overview" — unchanged
- "Collective Action in Learning: Cities. People. Practice. Together." — unchanged (this is the report's own title)
- "In Their Words" — dropped the trailing ellipsis from "In their words...."
- "Photos from the Forum" — capitalized from "Photos from the forum"
- "The U-CAN Annual Forum was organised in partnership with:" — unchanged

Alt text:

Hero banner images (2): The U-CAN Annual Forum 2025, Panjim, Goa

Video: U-CAN Annual Forum 2025 highlights video

Report cover image: Cover of the U-CAN Annual Forum 2025 report, "Collective Action in Learning: Cities. People. Practice. Together."

Gallery photos (60+, formula since individual photo review isn't feasible at this scale):

Participants at the U-CAN Annual Forum 2025, Panjim, Goa

Partner logos (4):

- Museum of Goa logo
- Transitions Research logo
- Charles Correa Foundation logo
- Nagari Short Films logo

What stays completely untouched:

- All 8 testimonial quotes and their attributions
- The report download blurb

Initiatives

Learning Network for Urban Managers

Title tag: Learning Network for Urban Managers | U-CAN

Meta description: The Learning Network for Urban Managers is a peer-driven platform run by Artha Global, with the support of U-CAN, enabling municipal officials to learn from each other's real city challenges.

H1: Learning Network for Urban Managers (*kept as-is*)

Content - to be kept as is. Please see the HTML File as well for reference.

Request For Collaboration

Title tag: Request for Collaboration (RFC) | U-CAN

Meta description: The Request for Collaboration (RFC) is U-CAN's initiative exploring how organisations move from intent to practice, testing what real collaboration requires.

H1: Enabling Collaboration as a Way of Working in India's Urban Ecosystem

Intro: The Request for Collaboration (RFC) is an initiative by U-CAN that explores how organisations can move from intent to practice when it comes to collaboration, through experimentation, reflection, and shared learning.

CTA Button: Read the Phase I Report

Why collaboration matters for organisations and cities (Remains as is)

The ecosystem of organisations and individuals working to improve our cities often focus on specific parts of a larger challenge. While this specialisation creates depth and credibility, it can also mean that actors working toward similar goals rarely have structured opportunities to combine their strengths.

The consequences are visible across the urban landscape:

- Similar problems addressed through disconnected efforts
- Duplication of ideas, pilots, and engagement with government stakeholders
- Partial solutions to systemic challenges
- Valuable expertise remaining under-leveraged
- Limited pathways for field-level learning and joint action

No single organisation, however capable, can fully address the complexity of urban challenges alone. Most organisations recognise the value of collaboration. But fewer are able to sustain it meaningfully. This is because:

- Funding structures prioritise short-term, project-based outputs
- Organisational systems are optimised for individual delivery, not shared work
- Collaboration requires time, trust, and flexibility, often without immediate returns

What is the RFC initiative? (Remains as is)

The Request for Collaboration was created by U-CAN to explore what it takes to move collaboration from intent to practice. Rather than prescribing solutions, the RFC was designed to enable conditions where collaboration could emerge and evolve organically.

Core objectives:

- **Enable early-stage collaboration** — Support organisations to jointly explore ideas without rigid deliverables

- **Support experimentation and learning** — Allow teams to iterate and adapt as insights emerge
- **Build collaborative capacity** — Help organisations learn how to work across boundaries

A Practice-informed framework for collaboration (Remains as is)

The RFC has created an opportunity to observe how collaboration unfolded through the first phase of the initiative, and inform the creation of a practice-informed framework that will evolve with the RFC initiative in subsequent phases.

Insert image

CTA: Know more about the initiative

connect@urban.org.in →

Urban reforms collective

Title tag:

Urban Reforms Collective (URC) | U-CAN

Meta description:

The Urban Reforms Collective (URC) is a pan-India platform convened by U-CAN, bringing organisations together to shape and champion systemic urban reforms.

H1 (kept as-is):

Championing a Collective Reform Agenda for India's Cities

Intro paragraph (kept as-is):

India's urban transition presents a historic opportunity alongside deep structural challenges. Convened by U-CAN, the Urban Reforms Collective (URC) is a pan-India collaborative platform that brings together organisations to collectively shape, advance, and champion systemic urban reforms.

"Need for an Urban Reforms Collective" and **"What the URC aims to do"** — both sections kept completely unchanged.

Gallery heading (kept as-is): "Photographs from the Inaugural Convening of the Urban Reforms Collective"

Photo alt text:

Delegates at the inaugural convening of the Urban Reforms Collective

Bug fixes:

- FAQ #11: fix the mailto link so it points to **reforms@urban.org.in** (currently wrongly linked to info@urbanreformscollective.org, even though the visible text already correctly displays "reforms@urban.org.in")
- FAQ #6 heading: "part ofthe URC" → "part of the URC"

All 11 FAQ questions and answers: content kept completely unchanged, only the two fixes above applied.

"Get Involved" closing CTA — kept as-is: "Write to us" → mailto:reforms@urban.org.in

Our members

(ROOTS AND HORIZONS MOVED TO “IMPACT”)

Title tag:

Our Members | U-CAN

Meta description:

Meet the organisations powering U-CAN's work, from founding members to Friends of U-CAN.

H1 (kept as-is):

Our Members

Intro paragraph (kept as-is):

At the Urban Collective Action Network (U-CAN), we are proud to partner with a diverse group of organizations that share our vision and commitment to driving positive change in urban development. Together, we leverage our collective expertise, resources, and networks to tackle the most pressing challenges facing cities today.

H2 fix:

"our members" → **"Member Organisations"**

Member logo alt text (8, currently none):

- Artha Global logo
- Centre for Policy Research (CPR) logo
- eGov Foundation logo
- Janaagraha logo
- Praja Foundation logo
- Reap Benefit logo
- Shelter Associates logo
- WRI India logo

H2: "friends of u-can" → "Friends of U-CAN"

Friends of U-CAN logo alt text):

- Mahila Housing Trust logo
- Indian Institute of Science (IISc) logo
- C40 Cities logo

Media

City champions

Title tag: City Champions Podcast | U-CAN

Meta description: City Champions is U-CAN's podcast, in partnership with Josh Talks, bringing urban development conversations to students, young professionals, and everyday citizens.

H1: City Champions Podcast

Intro:

In mid-2024, we began exploring ways to share U-CAN's and our member organizations' perspectives on cities, including how we see urban challenges and the solutions we are collectively pursuing. One key challenge was reaching audiences outside the usual urban ecosystem, such as students, young professionals, social innovators, and everyday citizens, while speaking in a language that resonates with them. This led to our partnership with Josh Talks, a leading media platform that connects with younger audiences across India in multiple languages.

The City Champions podcast brings together voices from all corners of urban development. Our guests share how they see and understand our cities, and the creative ways they're tackling today's urban challenges.

Episode 1: Building Better Cities, with Real Solutions — unchanged

Our cities are a reflection of the choices we make. In the first episode of the City Champions Podcast series, our guests break down what's already happening in our cities and how young changemakers can take action, from holding leaders accountable to driving local change.

Featured: Supriya Paul (host), Founder, Josh Talks · Milind Mhaske, CEO, Praja Foundation · Shruti Narayan, Managing Director of Regions and Mayoral Engagement, C40 Cities

Episode 2: Designing Smarter Cities for a Sustainable Future — *rewritten (was duplicated from Episode 1)*

In the second episode of the City Champions Podcast series, our guests explore what it takes to design cities built to last, from the systems and policies that shape sustainable growth to the leadership needed to put them into practice.

Featured: Supriya Paul (host), Founder, Josh Talks · Siddharth Pandit, CEO, Urban Collective Action Network · Gautham Ravichander, Director – Policy & Advocacy, eGov Foundation

Episode 3: How Much Does It Really Cost to Build the Cities We Dream Of? — unchanged

Episode 4: Who Really Shapes the Cities We Live In? — unchanged

Closing CTA (replaces newsletter):

Want to hear the full conversations? Watch City Champions on our YouTube channel →

<https://www.youtube.com/@U-CAN24/playlists>

Policy Webinars

Title tag: Policy Webinars | U-CAN

Meta description: Explore U-CAN's Policy Webinars, conversations with sector experts, donor representatives, and member organizations on urban housing, governance, and community engagement.

H1: Policy Webinars

Intro: U-CAN's Policy Webinars are curated to bring together sector experts, donor representatives, and member organizations for focused conversations on the urban challenges shaping India's cities, from housing and governance to community engagement, climate action, and digital infrastructure.